

How does tipping point risk management differ from non-tipping point risk management?

What-If DoView subsections sometimes represent risks you want to prevent before they occur. There are two types, each requiring a different response. Reversible Unwanted Subsections can be undone, so you can wait for clear evidence before acting to reverse them. On the other hand, Tipping-Point Unwanted Subsections, once triggered, cannot be reversed. In these cases, you have a limited 'Minimum Tipping-Point Prevention Window', which is the time between the tipping point being triggered time it will take to do your Tipping-Point Prevention Plan. Success depends on three factors: estimating when the tipping point could be triggered, knowing how long your Tipping-Point Prevention Plan (which you can also conceptualize as a DoView subsection) will take, and making sure you start before your Prevention Window closes.

Tipping point estimation requires a specific approach. Use “risk-likely-to-NOT-HAVE-BEEN-triggered-by” estimates, which means you include a margin for known and unknown unknowns, and bring forward your estimated trigger time. This approach is conservative in ensuring you act in time. In contrast, “risk-likely-to-HAVE-BEEN-triggered-by” estimates are conservative in the sense of wanting to be right and proving the TIPPING POINT HAS OCCURRED by the time of the estimate. Evidence thresholds differ: use a higher threshold for reversible risks (wait for clearer evidence to avoid unnecessary action) and a lower early-warning threshold for tipping risks (to make sure you have time to act while it’s still possible to prevent irreversible outcomes).

Draw the Tipping-Point Prevention DoView subsection so you can estimate how long it will take to implement. Compare this duration with your available Prevention Window to decide when you need to begin. Set indicators to track both your progress along the prevention pathway and your proximity to the tipping point. If your window is too short for your planned actions, you must speed up or take more radical action. The Risk Estimation and Acting Before the Tipping Point Prevention Window Has Closed Explainer sets this out.